

FATE, Aug. '78

# MAJOR COYNE AND THE UFO

## THE TRUE STORY

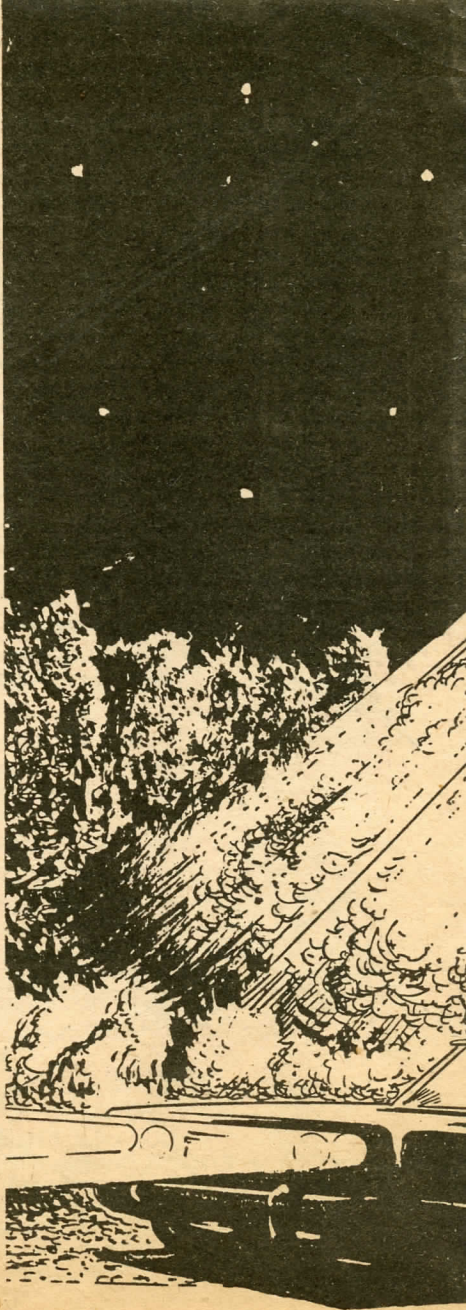
"It's going to ram us!" the pilot thought — then suddenly it stopped. . .

**By Jennie Zeidman**

Illustration by Allan Hendry, CUFOs

**F**IVE YEARS later the controversy still rages over what happened in the sky over Mansfield, Ohio, on the night of October 18, 1973, when the four-man crew of an army reserve UH-1H helicopter encountered a dark gray, metallic, cigar-shaped lighted object.

The crew won the *National Enquirer* Blue Ribbon Scientific Panel's \$5000 award for "the most scientifically valuable report of 1973." And not long afterwards *Aviation Week & Space Technology* editor Philip Klass (who declares flatly that he never has found a UFO case he couldn't solve) announced that his "rigorous investigation" of the case had determined that the object was merely "a fireball of the Orionid meteor shower." Klass insinuated that



the crew should return the money.\*

It is well known that approximately 90 percent of all reported UFOs have a conventional explanation. Klass' meteor explanation could easily have ended the matter but it did not.

Dr. J. Allen Hynek, professor of astronomy at Northwestern University, 21-year scientific consultant to the air force's Project Bluebook and now director of the Center for UFO Studies (CUFOS), spent the afternoon and evening of January 24, 1974, with the crew and with Federal Aviation Agency officials at the Cleveland airport. The evening meeting took place at dinner and afforded the crew the opportunity to talk in an open relaxed manner. Hynek, a professional astronomer for over 40 years, came away convinced that the object could not have been a meteor. And he asked me (I was his technical assistant in the early days of Project Bluebook) to reopen the case.

"We already have several hours of taped interviews," Hynek told me, "beginning with the excellent one with Sgt. John Healey, the helicopter medic, cut only 15 hours after the event. But we have never had a second-by-second analysis of what happened. Even Klass never came up with a total time that the object was in view but had only stated that 'there must have been a three-or-four fold distortion of time' and that 'the whole incident must have consumed a somewhat longer time than the crew later estimated.'"\*\*

"Those are bold statements," Hynek went on, "but they aren't documented nor are they very scientific. The time analysis is crucial."

He suggested I start from the beginning and try to establish what was taking place during each second of the event. Average meteor showers, he pointed out, are visible for only about two seconds; bright fireballs and bolides (exploding meteors) average about 10 seconds. Under the very best of conditions a meteor might conceivably remain visible for up to 30 or 40 seconds although he had never heard of such a case.

Hynek pulled his calculator toward him across the desk and worked it for a moment. "Theoretically," he said, "a meteor in a perfectly circular orbit at an altitude of 50 kilometers could remain visible, horizon-to-horizon, for 110 seconds. But of course that simply couldn't happen — it would be falling and burning the entire time."

Hynek described the Orionid meteor shower, seen every October, as "a piddling little meteor shower of swift streaks traveling 66 kilometers a second, which does not produce fireballs at all."

I knew from my own reading that glowing meteor *trains* may last many minutes and resemble jet contrails in the upper atmosphere.

\* \* \*

**MAJ. LAWRENCE J. Coyne**, pilot of the helicopter and the one whose name is usually associated with the incident, was 36 in October 1973 and had 19 years of flying experience. He is a big man with close-cropped hair and a rough complexion. A nonsense type and a military profes-

\*See "Phil Klass Debunks UFOs, Part Two" by George W. Easley, July 1975 FATE.

\*\*Philip J. Klass, *UFOs Explained* (Random House, 1974), pp. 333-346.



sional, he was frankly tired of the continuing publicity but since I represented Dr. Hynek he consented, albeit reluctantly, to see me. The tension between us eased when he learned I have been involved in ufology since 1953, have had some experience as a private pilot and am familiar with northeastern Ohio where he had his UFO experience.

The first thing I learned was that Coyne and Klass have never met!

"When Klass first called me," Coyne said, "I thought, 'Fine, this guy seems to know what he's talking about,' and he had an engineer on the line. I accepted his explanation because I had been scared and he offered an explanation. But when he sent me his book and we all read his explanation, we all said, 'This guy is full of beans.'"

Klass had had a brief talk-show chat with Sergeant Healey but never had even attempted to contact the other two crewmen.

Coyne and I met privately three times and talked by phone frequently. On two occasions we sat for more than an hour in a UH-1H helicopter reenacting the event. Every moment was taped. I also talked at length with the other three crewmen. Dr. Hynek was present during part of my five-hour session with copilot Lt. Arrigo Jezzi and my interview with John Healey took place in the presence of CUFOS consultant Dr. Tom Evans, professor of psychology at John Carroll University in Cleveland. Crew chief Robert Yanacsek and I met privately at the army reserve facility at Port Columbus and I spent another two hours reviewing the final report

with Coyne, Healey and Yanacsek.

I researched meteors in Ohio State University's astronomy library and at Perkins Observatory and Ohio Wesleyan University (Delaware, Ohio). I consulted Dr. William M. Protheroe, professor of astronomy at Ohio State, on several occasions. Afterwards I reread Klass' meteor explanation and was appalled. Not only had he not talked with the witnesses, it was beginning to look as if he had never even cracked a junior high school astronomy text.

\* \* \*

**G**RADUALLY THE pieces of the puzzle fell into place. The story did not differ from the original newspaper reports nor from Healey's tape-recorded account on the day after but the details were filling in.

As far as we now know, this is what happened:

Jezzi was at the controls. The helicopter was about seven miles south of Mansfield, cruising toward Cleveland at 2500 feet above sea level (1200 feet above Ohio's rolling hills and farmland), when John Healey, in the left rear seat, noticed a single red light off to the west. It was moving south, was brighter than a standard port-wing navigation light and carried none of the other lights, strobe or rotating beacon which FAA regulations require. But since the light was not relevant to traffic, he did not mention it. The light continued in level flight and disappeared out of his sight behind the helicopter.

Approximately two minutes later Yanacsek, in the right rear seat, noticed a single bright red light on the eastern horizon. The red light seemed

to be pacing the helicopter.

"I looked at it for some time before I mentioned it. It wasn't that important, it was so far away," Yanacsek reported. "It was too high, in my estimation, to be a radio tower but it was either that or an aircraft. I figured it was an aircraft. I must have watched it for a minute — oh, a minute and a half — before I said anything. *A long time.\** There was no question in my mind that it was man-made, whether it was a tower or a plane. It wasn't a star or anything. It was a red light and it was kind of hard to miss it."

Yanacsek finally mentioned the light. Coyne spotted it still on the horizon and told Yanacsek casually to "keep an eye on it."

After an estimated *additional* 30 seconds, Yanacsek reported that the light seemed to have turned and now was heading toward the helicopter. *By that time the light had been in continuous view for at least 90 seconds.*

Coyne looked again and agreed that the light was getting brighter. Because Jezzi's view was obstructed, Coyne took over the controls, immediately putting the helicopter into a "normal" descent at the rate of 500 feet per minute. They were fairly close to the ground; no need — yet — to take any drastic action.

Almost simultaneously Coyne pressed either his heel or his control-stick mike. They were already tuned into Mansfield.

"Mansfield Approach, this is army one-five-triple-four."

The response was immediate. "Go ahead, army triple-four."

"Mansfield Approach, do you have

any high-performance aircraft in your area at 2500 feet?"

There was no reply. The light was getting brighter and seemed to be following them down as they descended. Coyne estimated its speed at over 600 knots (684 mph).

"Call them," Coyne told Jezzi. There was a national guard F-100 base at Mansfield airport, eight miles northwest of their position. Probably one of the jets was coming in on a low approach. But at such high speed? FAA regulations specify that no aircraft shall fly faster than 250 knots (285 mph) under 10,000 feet above sea level. Within five miles of an airport the speed must be reduced to 200 knots.

Jezzi tried first to reach Mansfield Approach Control, then Mansfield Tower, on both UHF and VHF frequencies. There was no acknowledgment. The channel-change and mike-keying sounds were heard and then stopped, indicating that the stations were properly tuned in and that the equipment was transmitting correctly, yet when Coyne checked later with personnel at Mansfield, they said that although they remembered the initial transmission, they had no record of it on tape and that the last F-100 had landed at 10:47 P.M.

The red light continued to approach. Healey got out of his seat and stooped in the aisle next to Coyne and Yanacsek. "It was getting brighter and brighter," Healey said. "It was as bright as the approach lights of a 727 we had just seen at Port Columbus."

Coyne glanced at the altimeter. They were descending through 2200 feet now. He threw the collective pitch

\*Emphasis in Yanacsek's voice, not editorially added.



all the way down. The rate of descent increased to an indicated 2000 feet per minute. The last altitude he noticed was 1700 feet. (The encounter took place at exactly 1000 feet above sea level; the helicopter was about 650 feet above the treetops, not 400 feet as Klass guessed.)

*By now the light had been in continuous view for about 160 seconds.*

"It's going to ram us right by the door," Coyne thought. "Oh God, this is it!"

Suddenly the light was *there*.

"This thing came out of nowhere and just stopped," Yanacsek reported. "It was like the hull of a dark submarine. It was just stopped, and I mean *stopped*, for maybe 10 or 12 seconds. I really didn't expect us to collide because the object was obviously in control of the situation. The edges were sharp because it was an exceedingly bright starry night and the solid part of it blotted out the stars right behind it in an oval shape."

Now they could see that the red light was actually the nose light of a cigar-shaped or oval, slightly domed, gray, apparently metallic object. A white light was now visible at a slightly indented stern, and aft and below a bright green light became visible. All three lights were precisely positioned on the structure and all three cast reflections on the dark oval shape. (Klass said the entire object was glowing; Coyne, Healey and Yanacsek say it was not.)

The green light, like a maneuverable spotlight, swung upward, over the helicopter nose and into the cockpit, then entered the upper tinted "greenhouse" windows of the helicopter roof.

"Everything turned green," Coyne said. "These red instrument lights — everything. It was a pyramid-shaped beam that cut through the night. The farther it went, the wider it got. It shone down at right angles from the aircraft" — i.e., the UFO.

The light was green as it entered the front windshield but achieved maximum effect and brightness when it entered the tinted Plexiglas. Healey, Coyne and Yanacsek all agree that the beam was triangular or pyramid-shaped and that the object was dark, oval or cigar-shaped, and featureless — it had no engine pods, no numbers or logo, no wings, no tail structure. Jezzi who was looking through the "greenhouse" reported that from his angle, three feet to the left of the others, he could see only an intense white light which hovered briefly, then continued westward.

The object accelerated slowly until only the white "tail" light was visible. Coyne and Healey insist that as it neared the northwest horizon it made a decisive 45-degree turn to the right. Neither Jezzi nor Yanacsek reported this turn.

Finally, still very bright, the white light "snapped out" near or over the horizon. "I watched it for a couple minutes," Healey said, "and over the edge of the world it went." There had been no noise or turbulence from the object at any time.

"My God, what's happening?" Coyne exclaimed as he glanced back at his instruments and found that the helicopter was at 3500 feet and climbing 1000 feet a minute.

The collective, Coyne insists, was still in the full-down position; in other

words, the craft should have been *descending*. As he stared in amazement, the altimeter registered almost 3800 feet. The magnetic compass was spinning: 90, 180, 270, zero, 90. Coyne said it was still spinning the next day as Triple-Four sat on the flight line. The instrument had to be replaced.

Gingerly Coyne lifted the collective. Just the opposite of what he should do to stop the climb but there was no alternative; if you come to a door marked *push* and the door won't open, you instinctively try for a *pull*.

"I lifted the collective, pushed it back down, and the helicopter seemed to bump, like we hit turbulence then," Coyne said. "But the thing was already way to the west. It was already in the Mansfield area when we began to settle."

Jezzi's recollection differs. He believes they did not notice the climb until immediately *after* the object had disappeared. Either way the UFO was visible during the entire climb and if the helicopter was operating normally the 1800-foot, 1000-foot-per-minute climb must have taken 108 seconds. Of course, if the UFO had affected the helicopter, then the climb could have taken *any* length of time, from instantaneous levitation on up.

The various segments of the event add up to between 270 and 330 (or more) seconds, depending upon when the object was actually no longer visible. A safe estimate of the time would be 300 seconds, plus or minus 10 percent.

*Five minutes. Some meteor!*

\* \* \*

**W**HILE I WAS talking with the crew, a small UFO group in

Columbus, the Civil Commission on Aerial Phenomena, approached the problem from another angle.

On August 19, 1976, CCAP director Warren Nicholson published a brief recap of the Coyne case in the *Mansfield News Journal* and appealed to possible ground witnesses to come forward. On two previous occasions I had talked with such potential witnesses but had had to rule them out.

That same evening Nicholson received a call from Charles C., a youth who claimed that he, his mother and siblings possibly had witnessed the encounter between helicopter and UFO. (Mrs. C. requested anonymity.) Several days later Nicholson and his associate William E. Jones conducted the first of two extensive interviews with the family. Two hours of those interviews took place at the exact site of the family's observation. Later I spent an hour at the site with these witnesses.

At approximately 10:40 P. M. on October 18, 1973, Mrs. C. left the Mansfield home of her mother-in-law to return to her rural home southeast of the city. With her were her three children: Charles, then 13, Camille, 11, and Curt, 10, as well as a cousin Karen, 13.

As they drove south on Laver Road they saw a steady bright red light flying south "like a jet at medium altitude." The light attracted their attention because of its unusual shade of red and the fact that no other lights or colors were visible. Wondering why the aircraft had such unconventional lighting, they watched it continue southward and disappear over the trees.



Five minutes later (it was now just past 11 o'clock) they were driving east on Route 430 toward the Charles Mill Reservoir. The area is sparsely inhabited and the last 1500 feet of the approach to the bridge drops down from the hills into a desolate, flat and swampy area — a tangled, uninviting terrain. There was no other traffic. On the road ahead they saw — in their “one o'clock” position — a red and a green light, moving as a unit and seeming to descend toward them rapidly from the east. A small Cessna, perhaps, flying in the dark over the lake? No. The red light seemed to be leading; there was no noise and no shape was discernible. Mrs. C. slowed the car and finally pulled over onto the shoulder. Except for the car headlights the road was black as pitch.

The two lights slowed and moved along the right side of the car at a “low” altitude. They thought the object was less than 1000 feet high and about 500 feet south of them, over the swamp.

Suddenly the family saw another set of lights, some of them flashing, approaching from the southwest, at the car's “five o'clock” position. There was also “a thumping, a beating noise” from that direction. Mrs. C. thought the two sets of lights were helicopters about to crash. The two objects came together and the one with the steady lights assumed a position over the one with the blinking lights. They moved together slowly westward parallel with the road.

Everyone in the car started yelling at once. Over Mrs. C.'s protests Karen and Charles piled out and stood by the right rear fender.

“There was a whole bunch of noise, a big bunch of racket, a sort of rattling,” Charlie recalled. “It was like beating the air.” Charlie's words describe perfectly the very distinctive sound of a Huey helicopter.

“It looked like a blimp,” Charlie said. “It was a big ol' thing. Bigger than the helicopter. The ship was green. Then the green flared up. The helicopter was below the light. It looked like rays coming down. It lit up the helicopter and the car and the road and the trees. Everything turned green.”

Charlie and Karen believe they were outside the car less than a minute. When the green light flared up they became terrified and scrambled over each other to get back into the car.

Meanwhile, watching through the rear window, Curt reported that the object crossed the road from south to north. Mrs. C. drove the car on across the bridge “to get out of there.” According to Curt, the object, now apparently disassociated from the helicopter, paced the car eastward for a few seconds, then reversed its direction and climbed to the northwest, while the helicopter flew off in an apparently normal manner, climbing out over the lake to the northeast.

\* \* \*

**W**HAT DID Coyne and his crew see?

We don't know. We do know, however, what they did *not* see. The evidence clearly shows that the object was neither a meteor nor a high-performance aircraft. At the same time it seems very likely that the C. family did witness the encounter.

Klass concluded that the event took 85 seconds. But he should have known that meteors do not remain visible for even 85 seconds, nor do meteors look and move as did the object described by both air and ground witnesses.

Has the controversy been laid to rest? I doubt it. Klass, as a much-publicized UFO foe, has a vested interest in "solving" all cases. In all

likelihood he will hold tenaciously to his meteor theory despite the fact that the evidence makes it untenable.

But this fact remains: the Coyne encounter not only has stood up to the most searching scrutiny but actually has been strengthened by it. It is, in short, one of the best-documented high-strangeness cases in the history of UFO research.



### PERIL AT HOME

**L**T. COL. Thomas Fitzpatrick of Detroit, Mich., served in the Michigan Air National Guard for 21 years and after two years on active duty in the Korean conflict, returned unscathed to his base, the 127th Tactical Reconnaissance Wing in Inkster, Mich. In October 1968, getting out of his car in the driveway of his home, he was electrocuted when he stepped on a live wire that had fallen across his driveway. — *M.E. Sheffer.*



### LONG JOHN NEBEL DIES. . .

**L**ONG JOHN NEBEL, whose all-night radio talk shows entertained thousands of "night people" for 20 years, died of complications from cancer April 10, 1978, at New York City's Sheraton Hotel. He was 66.

"He was the first to do an all-night talk show on radio and the first to have a network talk show," said Dennis Israel, vice-president and general manager of WMCA, the station which carried Nebel's nightly program from midnight to 5:30 A.M. "His show was controversial, intelligent and a great part of history. There will never be

another Long John Nebel. It is an era that went away."

Long John, so-called because of his slender six-foot three-inch frame, got his start on all-night radio on WOR in 1956 and his show was almost an immediate success. His biographer Donald Bain attributed Nebel's popularity in part to his involvement in the occult. He invited persons who claimed to have come from outer space to appear on his show. Bain insists, however, that Nebel was not a believer. "He was one of the great put-ons of all time."